

French digital society: digital mediation professionals face the challenge of digital remoteness



COMPRENDRE

LA SOCIÉTÉ NUMÉRIQUE FRANÇAISE

LES PROFESSIONNELS DE LA
MÉDIATION NUMÉRIQUE AU DÉFI
DE L'ÉLOIGNEMENT NUMÉRIQUE



In 2021, the Digital Society Program of the French National Agency for Territorial Cohesion (ANCT), has launched a consultation for the production of a series of studies on the state of the art of the French digital society. It is within this framework that the Centre de recherche pour l'étude et l'observation des conditions de vie (CREDOC) and the Centre de recherche sur l'éducation, les apprentissages et la didactique (CREAD), associated with the GIS M@rsouin, are carrying out a diagnostic and analytical work that is giving rise to a series of thematic reports. The first edition, published in April 2023 [[/en/articles/the-french-digital-society-defining-and-measuring-digital-less/](#)] , focused on defining and measuring the phenomenon of digital distance. **The second edition of this series of studies follows on from the first, focusing on professionals in the digital mediation sector.** This article presents a summary of the latest study.

To quote the study :

ANCT, CREDOC, Université Rennes 2 CREAD-M@rsouin, La société numérique française: les professionnels de la médiation numérique au défi de l'éloignement numérique, 2025.

Study documents

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Growing need for digital support for the population

The rise of digital technologies has brought about a major transformation of activities and processes in our societies over the last twenty years. The persistence of **socio-numeric inequalities** despite the massive spread of digital infrastructures and equipment, and the presence of highly heterogeneous digital practices within the French population, have been strongly highlighted by the progressive digitization of all activities and processes in everyday life. Since the late 1990s, this observation has been accompanied by the introduction of various subsidized employment schemes: "youth jobs" at the end of the 1990s, then the "2,000 jobs for the future in digital public spaces" program in 2012, and more recently the "Digital Advisors" scheme, announced in November 2020, based on the recruitment and training of 4,000 digital mediators in a wide variety of structures (public and private). These successive initiatives reflect a response to the **population's growing need for digital support**, and have also contributed to a gradual and sometimes imprecise redefinition of the missions assigned to digital mediators, in a context of ongoing professionalization.

Digital mediation for the appropriation of technologies and the acquisition of a digital culture

A professional field rooted in popular education

Digital mediation, like other forms of mediation linked to adult education, has a **strong link with popular education**, which is concerned with civil and civic training. It is within the framework of popular education that mediation applied to the field of digital technologies has developed, advocating the dissemination of a **technical culture** defined as a minimum of knowledge and know-how enabling individuals to "reappropriate" technologies. The aim is to positively influence the **appropriation of** technologies by different audiences (i.e., the process by which an individual integrates a technical device into his or her practice, adapting it to his or her culture, needs and values), and thus enable their **empowerment** by taking into account the contexts of use as well as the socio-cultural characteristics of individuals.

There are professionals specifically trained and qualified as "mediators", for whom mediation is their core business and expertise, while other professionals (or even volunteers) engage in mediation activities with no real specific skills in terms of their initial training, and which are just another activity in their daily lives.

The current digital mediation landscape

In this context of multifaceted digital mediation and mosaics of players, ANCT's Digital Society Program plays a central role in identifying digital mediation professionals and venues. Based on its collaborative mapping work, **13,203 digital mediation venues** were listed in November 2024, mostly in mainland France, with strong regional differences: the regions of Nouvelle-Aquitaine, Hauts-de-France, Auvergne-Rhône-Alpes and, within the overseas departments, Réunion and Guadeloupe, have the highest number of digital mediation venues per inhabitant. **Interestingly, 80% of the French population has at least one professional digital mediation center in or near their commune** (67% of French metropolitans have a mediation center in their own commune, 13% can reach a mediation center in less than seven minutes by road). However, 20% have to drive 7 minutes or more to get there. Non-internet users, in particular, are more likely to live some distance from these services, with only 51% having local access. The analysis carried out on the basis of cartography does not include locations providing assistance exclusively in completing administrative procedures online. Indeed, while these places can help identify and direct people in difficulty towards digital mediation services, the help they provide is not part of a process of appropriating digital technologies.

Digital mediation: a test of professionalism

The dematerialization of administrative procedures at the crossroads of several professional groups

The dematerialization (or digitization) of administrative procedures has established itself as a new public service standard (the "Action publique 2022" plan aimed to dematerialize all administrative procedures by 2022). In cases where this digitization has replaced other channels of access to the administration (counter, postal service, telephone line), it implies an "obligation of connectivity" for citizens in the context of the administrative relationship. While the

digitized relationship with the administration and public services has simplified procedures for certain sections of the public, it has not benefited all categories of the population, confronting some of them with complex digital and, above all, administrative practices, which can go so far as to fuel the phenomenon of non-use of rights. It is also interesting to note that the process of dematerializing administrative procedures has helped to blur the boundaries between professional groups: digital mediators, social workers and administrative mediators.

Impact on digital mediators

In order to meet the growing demand for support in digital administrative relations, often characterized by the social urgency of applicants, digital mediators are sometimes obliged to provide administrative support, the nature and volume of which vary according to the audience and location. As a result, many digital mediators are confronted with administrative procedures for which they are not trained, have no specific resources at their disposal, and have no contacts in public administrations. This situation, marked by a certain vagueness, sometimes leads them to do things "in the place" of the people they assist, for want of anything else to do, to the detriment of the emancipatory approach inherent in digital mediation. In this respect, requests to digital mediators for support in carrying out administrative procedures online generally constitute a "**test of professionalism**" for the latter, by putting into tension what they consider they should be doing and what they are actually doing.

Impact on social workers

The dematerialization of the relationship with the administration for access to social rights is also leading to a reconfiguration of social work. **Some social workers see dematerialization as a source of problems not only for their beneficiaries, but also for themselves**, by causing both a de-skilling of their social mediation missions and an additional workload. In this respect, the unease expressed by social workers is reinforced by the fact that, like digital mediators, they often have to act in the absence of a clear mandate. Some studies show that not all professionals in the social sector are involved in digital support, and some exclude digital uses from their field of intervention. These professional postures depend on contextual variables such as working conditions and workload, and individual

variables relating to their levels of digital competence, as well as their conception of the profession.

Impact on administrative mediators

Administrative mediators, often represented by reception staff at shared access points to public services such as Espace France Services, are now directly involved in helping people complete administrative procedures, particularly online. This type of administrative mediation seems to be evolving from a reception and guidance function to one of assisting users with their online procedures, once again confronting professionals with a reconfiguration of their activity. In contrast to digital mediators and social workers, **this change seems to be viewed positively by the administrative staff concerned**, as a "revalorization of counter work" that has traditionally been depreciated. Invested with an institutionally-recognized mission to assist with administrative procedures, and insofar as they benefit from training that enables them to familiarize themselves with administrative procedures and interfaces, access point agents are much better equipped and trained than digital mediators or social workers to help people with their administrative procedures. They can also interact more easily with the various organizations concerned, thanks to privileged access. What's more, these administrative mediation professionals are also more familiar with existing solutions for dealing with the ethical and legal issues involved in supporting online administrative procedures (privacy, consent and establishing responsibilities).

A necessary link between digital mediation and administrative mediation

By **disintermediating the citizen-administration relationship**, the digitization of administrative procedures requires not only physical access to the Internet and certain technical skills, but also, and above all, a mastery of language, writing and, more broadly, administrative procedures. Thus, in this context, the subject of access to rights relies on a "practical sense of administration", i.e. on **a set of administrative skills that are not initially linked to digital technology** (identifying the right contact, translating one's situation into administrative categories, identifying the status of documents, reporting a possible problem, etc.). What's more, according to the Baromètre du numérique 2022, it's interesting to note that one in two French people claim to experience difficulties in carrying out online

procedures. This high proportion suggests that we need to **think about the impact of dematerializing administrative procedures beyond the technological question**, in relation to people's digital skills. However, this does not rule out the possibility that dematerialization may confront certain sections of the public with complex digital practices.

In line with the above-mentioned professional reconfigurations, these factors suggest that **support for online administrative procedures should be based on the right balance between digital mediation and administrative mediation**. The complementary nature of the work carried out by these professionals appears to be a key factor in avoiding the burden and responsibility for the smooth running of administrative procedures being shifted onto individuals.

State of knowledge of digital mediation facilities

Whatever the difficulty encountered, whether digital and/or administrative, **a majority of French people (52%) say they know of at least one digital mediation point**. The places that are most firmly rooted in the local landscape (town halls, media libraries and libraries) are the best known. Non-internet users who are farthest from the digital world are better informed about the existence of these places than Internet users who have difficulties with the digital world, probably due to their socio-demographic profile and greater dependence on Internet access points. Geographical proximity to a place of digital mediation influences not only knowledge but also the diversity of the types of places known. **Living in a commune where there is a digital mediation center boosts awareness of the various places where digital help can be obtained**, and encourages people to perceive personal assistance in a dedicated place as a solution when digital difficulties arise. For Internet users who feel they have not fully mastered the digital world, living in a commune with a digital mediation center encourages the identification of personal support or a group course as the most suitable way to improve their mastery of digital tools.

Enabling environments to support professional development in digital mediation

A professional sector to be structured

Against a backdrop of digitization of society and persistent digital inequalities, if the job of providing support for digital uses with a view to digital and social inclusion is of prime importance, **the question of support and training for digital mediation players themselves is particularly central**. As Denouël and Granjon (2023) point out, "Digital mediators today need, in their initial and "lifelong" training, to acquire multidisciplinary knowledge enabling them to carry out an ever broader and more varied set of tasks that are evolving as the various spheres of activity become increasingly technologized". This need echoes the objectives formulated in the roadmap for the national digital inclusion policy 2023-2027 (France Numérique Ensemble) aimed, in particular, at structuring the industry of digital mediation players and developing training.

Towards an empowering work environment

Numerous studies of adult training now tend to show that **the development of skills is in fact the result of an articulation between the individual's internal resources and external resources linked to the work environment**. The capability approach opens up important perspectives for understanding the way in which individuals are enabled (or not), in a given organization and work context, to seize and use the resources present in their environment and acquire new skills. The work environment can indeed foster professional development by activating a number of levers, such as :

- work content: by varying the activities, allowing time for reflexivity and analysis of one's practice, or offering to confront situations corresponding to the individual's zone of proximal development;
- the way work is organized: this can help develop skills such as cooperative practices, initiative-taking and freedom of action, the possibility of mentoring new arrivals, and participation in work groups;
- human resources management and training: by facilitating access to training in order to build capacity for action.

Meeting the needs of digital mediators to tackle digital inequalities

To meet the challenge of the social phenomenon of digital remoteness, we first need to **identify the specific needs of digital mediators, by working with them to identify their needs in their local areas**. In particular, we need to meet the initial and lifelong training needs of these professionals, based on multi-disciplinary training that will enable them to carry out a wide and varied range of tasks. At the same time, **a clarification of roles and tasks between the various mediation and social support professionals** could also be envisaged. In this respect, the core business of digital mediators, rooted in popular education, is to encourage users to engage in a reflexive process of appropriating digital technologies and acquiring a digital culture. Administrative mediators, on the other hand, appear to be better equipped to provide more ad hoc assistance with online administrative relations. This differentiation should be accompanied by **networking between the various players**, including social workers, as they are often part of the same territorial ecosystem. Such networking would appear to be a prerequisite for **the activation of capacity-building dynamics** adapted to the specific features of the territory in which they operate, in the interests of **local digital mediation**.

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